

Lost in the Vale

Told through the never-ending nightmare of one family, Warrier's novel mirrors the fate of the post-1990 Kashmir



THE HOMECOMING
by SHASHI WARRIER
Penguin
Price: Rs 299
Pages: 304

■ By Dilip Bobb

It started with the Cold War spy thriller, authors like Le Carré and Deighton, who based their books on contemporary historical events. Since then, the literary marriage of fact and fiction has been firmly established, with Dan Brown taking it to another level. Shashi Warrier is their Indian clone. His earlier works—*The Sniper*, *Hangman's Journal*—were based on real-life situations with a topical theme. In his latest, *The Homecoming*, the contemporary theme is the turmoil in Kashmir and its impact on one family in Srinagar.

Javed Sharif is a successful carpet exporter who lives in Bangalore. He is a widower with a daughter and two sons. One son and the daughter live in the ancestral home in Srinagar with his parents. Javed plans a surprise trip to Srinagar for his father's birthday but the celebrations bookmark a series of tragic events that bring his world crashing down. The family is torn apart against the back-

drop of the insurgency in Kashmir, its politics, terrorism, and the oppressive weight of the security forces.

Warrier visited Kashmir during his stint as a journalist which gives the book the stamp of authenticity. The characters and events are entirely believable; indeed, they are the story of Kashmir post-1990. The son is accused of being a terrorist and jailed under the anti-terror ordinance without recourse to the legal process. There is Javed's brother, a local politician on the make, who joins the government and then has to compromise on his ethics, his ethnicity, and even his family by refusing to help his nephew get out of jail because it could jeopardise his political career. There are others, the senior policeman, once close friend now tormenter, crooked lawyers, corrupt officials, trigger-

happy security personnel creating more militants than they arrest or kill, and those fleeing the border areas to escape the shelling from Pakistan, refugees in their own land.

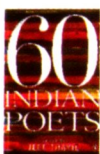
But whose land is it anyway? It's a question that lies at the heart of the angst of Kashmir, a question that has torn the state apart and with it, thousands of families. Warrier's book mirrors contemporary Kashmir, told through the troubles and trauma of one family. Through them, he manages to bring alive the fear and suspicion, the paranoia and bitterness and the depth of the self-perpetuating rift between the Valley and the 'India' referred to in everyday conversation. It is difficult to tell fact from fiction, a tribute to the author's journalistic background. This is, at its heart, a story of betrayal, personal and political, painted on a contemporary canvas. There are flaws, though. Warrier tends to overplay his literary hand by weaving too many strands into the storyline: at times, Javed's never-ending nightmare seems forced and somewhat overdone. In the context of a state convulsed by



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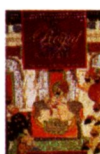
conflict and contradiction, excess may be a recurring theme but often the book tends to ignore the partition where fact ends and fiction begins. For all that, this is a timely reminder that the crisis in the Valley is not just about security and secessionism, Pakistan and political one-upmanship. It is about people and families. Here, the tragedy of one family becomes a metaphor for the tragedy of Kashmir. ■

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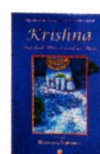
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